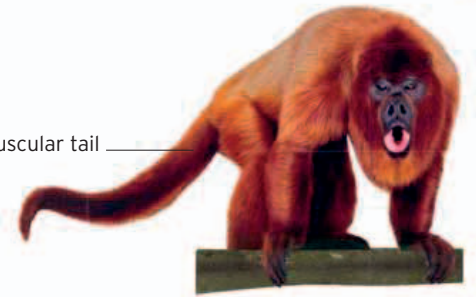




thick, muscular tail _____



Red howler monkey

Alouatta seniculus

The growling roars of red howler monkeys are among the most distinctive sounds of the Amazonian rainforest. Just before dawn, each troop starts to call from the treetops to announce ownership of their home range, and other groups in the area may reply. Adapted hyoid bones in the monkeys' throat amplify the sounds, which can be heard up to 3 miles (5km) away. Both sexes roar. Male howlers react most to the calls of males in neighboring troops, while females respond most to the roars of other females, which are higher pitched.

Chunky monkeys

Red howlers are big, solid monkeys that move more slowly than many other monkeys. They typically spend most of their waking hours resting or digesting food in the forest canopy. Their prehensile tails have a bald patch near the underside of the tip to help grip branches. They feed on leaves and fruit—especially figs—and when they find a large fruiting tree, will guard it against rival groups. Red howlers periodically go to the ground to eat clay, which contains salts and minerals that help to neutralize toxins in the leaves they eat.

A red howler monkey troop usually has from three to a dozen members, led by an adult male that remains dominant for several years. Females mate for the first time when around five years old, giving birth to a single baby after a seven-month gestation. Babies cling to their mother's belly for the first month, then ride piggyback, and are independent at six months old. Despite their large size, red howler monkeys are preyed on by harpy eagles. On spotting danger, they quickly grunt warnings to alert the rest of the group.

△ BEARDED MALE

Adult male howler monkeys, which are much heavier than females, have a long, full beard.

▷ URSINE HOWLERS

Many howler monkeys are named after their predominant fur color. There are brown and black species as well as ones with red fur, such as the ursine howler (*A. arctoidea*).



Howler monkeys are the **loudest land animals**—their calls reach 90 decibels